

In Search of a Concept of Education: Liberal Education and the Case of India¹

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Despite the centrality of the institution of the university to liberalism, the trajectory of the institution in non-western, postcolonial democracies like India has scarcely received attention. The subject has rarely generated the kind of scholarly enquiry and reflection that liberal political institutions like the state and other institutions of the civil society have. Indeed, the dominant framework has been to think of education (higher or otherwise) and its attendant institutions as concomitant with the nation-state, often thought of as serving no other purpose than the state's developmental agenda.

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Introduction:

A perusal of the existing scholarship on the institution of the university and higher learning in India in the last few years makes two points abundantly clear:

a) Much of the literature that exists on the institution of university in India is replete with the rhetoric of crisis, often envisaging both the problem and the solution in largely bureaucratic terms, dwelling more on structural, financial and administrative aspects on the one hand and on issues of social justice on the other. This lack of depth to discussions around education is in strange contrast to the West² where one finds that any articulation of crisis is accompanied by serious reflections on the institution of the university and the idea of liberal education it embodies, a body of literature that has developed into a flourishing genre. Indeed, as has been pointed out by scholars on the subject, few ideas have had as clear a historiography as does the idea of the university in the West and although other institutions have at times been examined for their “underlying idea”, and conceptual foundations, none of them has inspired a literature that constantly builds on itself and is itself an inextricable part of the institution that it constantly refers to (Rothblatt and Wittrock 1993; Rothblatt 1997).³

This prolific body of literature provides us a way of organizing our thoughts about the activity and practice of higher learning. The university, in the absence of the idea, would be utterly shapeless, possessing no means of distinguishing itself from other institutions and corporate bodies. In non-western postcolonial contexts such as ours, it is precisely the absence of this genre that is particularly striking.

b) A second point of contrast is that despite the Marxist, feminist and postcolonial criticism of liberal education that we have witnessed in the last two decades, liberal education continues to be of significance in the West. The recent criticism of liberal education that it has been in the service of particular class, caste, gender or imperial interests rather than foster the realization of a genuine freedom as it was originally meant to, can be seen as an attempt to uphold the ideal even more “purely”⁴. Interestingly, this criticism has been interpreted as a plea to include more and more texts

and viewpoints from marginalized groups but not as a challenge to the very idea of liberal education itself. On the contrary, in the Western academia, liberal education and “liberal arts education” continue to generate much passion either as something one needs to assert in these global times in the wake of increasing utilitarianism or as the decline of something precious, the loss of which we need to note and lament.⁵

In short, we could conclude that the crisis in the Western university is articulated in terms of the decline of the University of Culture (Readings 1996⁶; Pelikan 1992; Readings 1996) and the corresponding idea of liberal education, as a “crisis in the very idea of education” or in terms of a *loss* of concept of education (the presumption being that there *did/does* exist something worthy of being preserved but now faces disintegration). However, in India, the crisis is expressed in terms of liberal education and its corresponding notion of liberal knowledge, learning and selfhood not taking root, of the “*inadequacy* of a borrowed structure,” sometimes characterized as a “*lack*”, “*incompleteness*,” “*failure*” on part of Indians to acquire certain critical normative goals or more recently in terms of *alienness* of liberal institutions and concepts⁷(Altbach and Selvaratnam 1989; Singh 2003; Nandy 2000; Shah 2005). The two kinds of narratives of crisis make it clear that the crisis in higher education is experienced differently in the two contexts and for analytical purposes, it is necessary to separate the two strands in order to contextualize the experience of the crises and gain a better handle on what is at stake in these debates.

In the first section, I examine a debate around liberal education and the concept of the university in India that took place in 2008 in order to demonstrate that there is an intelligibility issue when we discuss the idea of liberal education in the Indian context. In the second section, I revisit some of the early twentieth century debates around the Indian student in order to show how these anxieties are not new but marked the contours of the early nineteenth century debate around university education as well. This section shows how the learning goals posited by the institution of the university was constantly frustrated and considers the explanations forwarded in order to understand the problem. In the third section, I argue that any attempt to recast the problem of unintelligibility of learning goals and understand the way liberal knowledge and learning is received in India requires us to relocate liberal education back in its specific cultural and historical context and revisit the very conception of education, knowledge, self-formation and learning it involves. This will enable us to provide a more accurate characterization of the crisis in higher education in a non-western, postcolonial context such as ours.

Section 1

The Debate around the Idea of University and Liberal Education in India

In a rather striking manner, the much discussed Yashpal Report (2009), regarded as a blueprint of the reform initiated in higher education in India in last few years, turns around the idea/concept of the university, often evoking the concept as some kind of a standard against which to benchmark other institutions of higher education. This is evident in several of its recommendations: The IITs and IIMs, though “bright spots in the otherwise dismal scenario of higher education in India,” need to strive to be models of all-round excellence like MIT and CALTECH and transform themselves from mere “undergraduate factories” into full-fledged universities (14-5), private and commercial institutions which have only profit as motive without being comprehensive universities, must be only diploma and certificate awarding institutions and not degree conferring ones (35), deemed universities should be rigorously evaluated to see if they fulfil the holistic and universal concept of university outlined in the report and be stripped of their status as universities if they do not meet the required standards (37), single-disciplined institutions must offer a broad range of courses before they qualify as a university (7) and so on.

Interestingly, the IITs, in response to some of the recommendations of the Yashpal committee went on a formal protest against the proposed change in their identity which required them to change in their status and form into universities, arguing that if offering a wide range of courses was the criterion for evaluation, they were already doing so. Two of the IIT directors reacted by saying that the proposal was “shocking” and “the state of India’s university system is appalling. The IITs are better only because we are different” (*The Telegraph*, September 13, 2008). Arguing that unlike most other universities, the IITs allowed undergraduate engineering students the option of taking courses in humanities, management or from any other department alongside their principal course, to convert IITs from such a liberal education system, into rigid universities would be a retrograde step (*The Telegraph*, November 22, 2008). It was also pointed out that it was ironical that when other technical schools and universities were aiming to be more like IITs, the IITs were being asked to be more like universities, which had the reputation of being moribund institutions in India.

The above debate foregrounds a contradiction that runs through the Yashpal report. On the one hand, the report, like much of the scholarship on higher education, identifies the IITs, IIMs and IISc as institutions that excel, and our universities as being in deep crisis, having lost their primacy in the higher educational sector. On the other hand, it suggests that the solution lies in transforming these “spots of excellence” into universities. How does one understand this contradiction? One could of course argue that the Yashpal report works with the normative Western model represented by the likes of MIT and CALTECH, many of them considered as embodiments of liberal education, and seen as eminently worthy of being emulated world over. However, in the absence of a diagnosis of why Indian universities are not considered as great embodiments of liberal education, despite many of them having a history of two centuries, there is little guarantee that converting IITs to the university model will make them yield the desired results. This anxiety is what appears to be at the back of the protest by IITs⁸. However, interestingly, both sides seem to agree that liberal education is desirable and without it the status of the institution as a centre for higher learning is seriously under question.

If in the Yashpal report, the mismatch between our current universities and the nineteenth-century ideal of the university of culture is one way to evaluate the crisis, Dhruv Raina in his “Re-imagining the University: After the Yashpal Committee Report”, (2009, 87-9) questions the very idea of the nineteenth-century university of culture as an ideal for contemporary times. Pointing out that the era of the Humboldtian University or the University of Culture was the result of simultaneous revolutions in the cognitive, intellectual and institutional realms, he observes that today the modes of knowledge production have changed drastically necessitating the re-imagining of the university as an institution. Thus, the crisis for Raina is the mismatch between an old idea of the university and a “new” cognitive revolution which the old idea is unable to accommodate. However, Raina says little about what these new forms are and in what sense they constitute a cognitive revolution, for any such revolution can be recognized as such only when it is mapped against the background of the cognitive breakthrough made possible by what is referred to as the Humboldtian moment. Also puzzlingly, no such need to re-imagine the university anew is articulated in the case of well-known universities like MIT, Cornell, Harvard or any of the Ivy League universities in the West. Moreover, in the same article, Raina himself points out that one of the primary tasks that needs to be undertaken is to understand why post-independent Indian universities failed to cultivate research, thereby drawing attention to the failure of the “old” idea much before we entered “post-industrial” times of ‘cognitive revolution’ as well. This takes us back to the question of why the “older” idea of the University of Culture and liberal education and learning associated with it fails to take root in our context. What kind of learning is higher learning in universities all about and why is liberal education considered as a touchstone which measures the “health” of this form of learning and knowledge?

Liberal Education: Cause and Solution of the Crisis?

The idea of liberal education has come to occupy a peculiar space in the Indian imagination. The mainstream scholarly literature on higher education, mainly those examining the rapid growth of the private sector in higher education in India, identifies liberal education as the cause for the crisis in higher education where liberal education is largely associated with the basic Arts and Sciences in which maximum number of students are enrolled, producing students with minimal linkages to the world of work. Thus, Pawan Agarwal points out that the expansion of higher education was largely confined to undergraduate programmes in Arts, Science and Commerce till about the 1980s (2006, 47-8) without much connection to the professional lives of students. However, he observes that, after the 1980s there has been a shift from liberal education which had “inner development” of the student as the primary focus to professional training, a world-wide trend whose effects are still being observed. Similarly, Devesh Kapur (2008, 66-9) evaluating the arguments of the partisans of liberal education that it produces students who are more open to diversity, have stronger humanitarian values, adaptable analytical and critical thinking skills and plays an important role in shaping the moral values of the student, notes that there is little by way of research to support these claims and produces counter claims which argue that liberal education may not only fail to produce open-minded citizens but may even increase political and societal divisions. Thus, according to some, we have had too much of liberal education.

If for some liberal education is the cause of the crisis, for certain others it is the solution. More concerned about the lack of internal dynamism of universities and the nature of the educated subject in our context when compared to the West, the proponents of this view see liberal education as what needs to be adopted from more successful models (Yashpal 2009). Here, by liberal education they do not mean just the presence of universities or basic Liberal Arts and Sciences, but a certain mode of thinking which one brings to the study of different kinds of subjects, whatever they may be.

However, some scholars argue that the liberal model of education which upholds the idealist conception of education according to which knowledge has to be acquired for its own end, despite the rhetorical value that it had in State policy or Supreme Court related judgments, was never really actualized in real terms in the Indian case at any point in its history. It has been pointed out that English education was basically seen as “useful education” even when it dealt with literary texts and the Bible, an education whose use was mainly to get into administrative service and the contradictions between the educational goal of knowledge for its own sake and useful knowledge had little purchase in the Indian context even during nationalist times (Sebastian 2007).

When people refer to liberal education, they have different referents in mind – some refer to the institution of the university, some to Liberal Arts education specifically, some to English education and some to an abstract ideal or a mode of thinking cultivated by exposure to a broad range of courses. It is simultaneously posed as a cause for the crisis and as a solution. Paradoxically, we have too much of liberal education according to some, and too little of it or an incomplete version of it, according to others. For some, it “liberates” one from the oppressive forces of tradition leading students to freedom and for certain others liberal education is the most “illiberal” because it produced consent for colonial rule or because it deligitimizes community “truths”.⁹

This lack of consensus and incoherence in the debate is puzzling given that liberal education is the only theory of education that we have, the only frame through which we can organize or even begin thinking about the complex space of higher education. Thus, when we people say liberal education has not taken root in India, it should be a cause for worry because it is the only evaluative frame we have through which we understand the activity of “higher” education, providing both State

policy and institutional practices a certain conception of institutional goals for higher education. Or we should be able to provide an alternative conception of education through which we can begin to think about and theorize the activity/practice. We cannot maintain a casual agnosticism regarding this issue. One way of even beginning this task is to account for this incoherence in the debate around higher education today. The lack of a stable referent in our context is more than a mere terminological or a semantic quibble, indicative of some kind of unintelligibility in our context, of the learning goals posited by the very idea of liberal education. What is the nature of the knowledge and learning goals posed by liberal education? Why are these learning goals unintelligible in our context? When people say that liberal education does not take root here, what indeed is it that does not take root? – are questions that need to be answered even before we begin to conceptualize what is happening under the rubric of liberal education.

A quick examination of the debates on education in India makes it evident that these anxieties around university education that I have detailed above are not new. What is striking and relevant for our purposes is that while the specific details of the case may vary, the larger concerns of the debate have remained more or less the same since the late nineteenth century. In the next section, I would like to revisit the late nineteenth and early twentieth century debates around the learning abilities of the Indian student in order to show the points of similarities and consider the explanations that have been forwarded to understand the problem.

Section 2

Revisiting the Early-Twentieth Century Debates on University Education, Knowledge and Learning

If in the early decades of the nineteenth century, the British expressed great optimism that the introduction of Western education would infuse in the Indian student a desire and sensibility for Science and Arts, this optimism was slowly replaced by the anxiety that Indian students did not understand the value, purpose and principles of modern knowledge and instead largely learnt it by rote, often swallowing large chunks of information without digesting them. While nobody disputed the growing popularity of Western education among the natives, it was observed that the popularity was more due to modern knowledge being an essential pre-requisite for employment, with a vast majority of the university students aiming to secure employment in one or the other form of Government service. It increasingly came to be lamented that Indian students largely pursued knowledge for instrumentalist reasons and that modern knowledge was valued as a means to an end rather than valued as an end in itself.¹⁰

Thus, by the turn of the century, close to almost a century after the first college was set up in India,¹¹ an overwhelming concern emerged about the purported failure in the dissemination of modern knowledge. The “pass-man” and “the crammer” almost became synonymous with the Indian student, with the “peculiar” ways of the student emerging sometimes as a source of frustration and sometimes as a target of ridicule. For example, a professor who deposed as a witness in the tenth sitting of the Universities Commission in 1902 to discuss the various problems confronting university education in the country, lamented about the undergraduate student thus: “the duty of an examiner is depressing in the extreme, not only on account of the excessive percentages of candidates who fail but much more on account of the character of the work of those who pass. In a large proportion of the cases, the books are not really understood, and the candidate passes because he has amassed a sufficient quantity of various information to secure him the required marks.” (*Educational Review*, 1902, 278) Some complained that a “large class of candidates do not care for knowledge but care for only that piece of paper which has acquired in India a market value never dreamt of by the founders of the universities.” (278) A few also forwarded explanations for this dismal scenario: the cause for this,

according to one of the witnesses was “the present character of the people of this country” and as long as young men themselves and their fathers and guardians held a purely utilitarian conception of education, it would be impossible to make education what it ought to be. (282)

Certain others identified the abundance of “inferior faculties” like the precocious ability to memorize in Indian students as a cause: “Cram is a name for special effort in committing to memory...It is true that the faculties of acquisition and retention are far inferior to the power of philosophic discussion and original investigation. But the inferior faculties are abundant and the superior are rare. Students must exercise what they possess.” (179) Acknowledging that the possession of a powerful memory was desirable in itself, some pointed out that “the evil consists in committing to memory things imperfectly understood which cannot become a part of the student’s permanent mental furniture.” (178) The Indian student, some rued, “memorizes, passes, and forgets and is entirely content.” (348)

Observations of Dr. Stein

Some accounts went a step ahead and tried to understand cramming as not only an undue exercise of memory but as the lack of (or the insufficient exercise of) the higher faculties of reason. An interesting conversation between Dr. Stein, PhD, Inspector of Schools, who himself was an educational officer and an Indologist by training and Mr. Bannerjee, one of the Commission members is revealing in this regard and worthy of being quoted at length (343-5)¹². Dr. Stein, observing that the European science and culture which the Indian universities are called upon to diffuse is in reality as foreign to the Indian mind as to the Chinese, located the greatest obstacle in the “deep-rooted difference in inherited notions and manners of thought which separated the Indian mind and the Western”. Stein argued that a form of academic control and reform that confined itself to a mere fixing of courses and conducting exams was grossly insufficient to secure either thoroughness of knowledge or the wide spread of the methods of thought which was more important than the bare knowledge itself. The weakest aspect of the Indian educational system, Dr. Stein pointed out, was the complete absence of anything resembling original research, which in his opinion was the only real academic work. Quoting fellow-scholars who occupied Sanskrit chairs in European universities and who expressed surprise at the fact that despite the spread of higher learning in India, “there should be such a rarity of contributions by Indian scholars, indicating some measure of original research in the closely allied fields of Indian philology, archaeology and history,” Dr. Stein argues that for oriental scholars like him who had closely observed the working of the educational system in India, this was not surprising at all. The main reason was the failure to develop in the student the faculty of historical reasoning, which in itself was rather foreign to the Indian student and without which no research in any field was possible.

Contrasting the case of India with Japan which in a short span of time had managed to achieve greater success than India in building up the Imperial University of Tokyo and had managed to do more original research in Sanskrit in twenty years than India in the previous hundred years, Dr. Stein attributed the reasons to the difference in the reasoning faculty between the Indian, Japanese and European mind. When asked by Mr. Bannerjee if the methods and processes of human reasoning were not fundamental in their nature and same across all races of mankind, Dr Stein replied that they were not and that human brains worked differently in different orders of civilization.

When pressed for evidence for his hypothesis about the nature of the Indian students’ mind, Stein mentions three points from his own experience as a teacher as the Principal of the Oriental College, Lahore: a) Unlike the European student “who seeks to prove chronology almost as one would prove a proposition of Euclid and he collects and coordinates the innumerable detached evidences with tireless industry and patience”, the Indian mind has an utter disregard for proving anything, uncritically accepts the indigenous chronology taught by ancient books and “is not even sensible of the

logical force of evidences when they are produced before him". As instances that demonstrate the above claims, he notes that when an Indian student is shown that when one authors alludes to another, the author who makes the allusion must have lived in a period subsequent to the author who is alluded to, the student is quite unable to see that this reasoning is persuasive and if the indigenous chronology reverses the respective periods of the two authors, the student's faith in indigenous chronology is not the least bit shaken. b) This does not mean that a European teacher who argues against an inherited doctrine, however convincingly, fails to drive the conclusions into the Indian student's head. It only meant that the student usually accepts anything from the instructor, not because the force of the argument convinces him but because it is part of his nature to offer least critical resistance. Even when he tried to ignite sparks of reason by putting forth difficult questions and a variety of conflicting opinions and asking them which particular opinion they prefer to adopt, the answer would inevitably be, "What is *your* opinion, Sir" or "What do you wish us to believe about it Sir?" In short, he clarifies, it is not that the Indian student *cannot* exercise the reasoning faculty on logical and critical lines but that he *does not* ; (Italics mine) c) the Indian student does not even think it necessary to give a reason for the faith that is in him. As an example, he points that no Indian student can give you any reason as to why he believes in the transmigration of souls and the doctrine is accepted uncritically, without reflection. "It is this, I maintain, that marks the essential difference between the Indian boy and the European boy. In this country boys do not start life with the same splendid mental inheritance which gives European boys the advantage. The European habit of coolly and confidently referring to every point to the ultimate arbitrament of the inner judgment is utterly wanting in the Indian."

When asked for an explanation for why the Indian student's mind was so, Stein attributes the cause to the "intellectual self-suppression" that resulted from the unfortunate indigenous system which passed on the blind veneration of dogmatic teaching, deeply inculcating in the Indian student an absolute trust in the *Guru*. The only reform worth attempting according to him was not to tinker with courses and attempt minor reforms, but work towards the supplantation of the indigenous methods of teaching which are essentially dogmatic and non-logical by western methods which are essentially inquisitive and reasoning. He would not want this transformation accomplished in a moment even if such a thing were possible, for "As an archaeologist and an Indologist, it is part of my work to study the surviving relics of ancient civilization, and if the existing system of higher education in India were to pass away very quickly, I should be deprived of some very interesting specimens for my mental museum."

One can, on the face of it, observe an apparent contradiction in Steins' arguments: on the one hand, he observes that the Indian student accepts easily and uncritically, whatever the instructor says. But at the same time, he also notes that no evidence shakes the Indian student's faith in indigenous chronology. This indicates that the modern methods and indigenous systems do not seem to collide in some direct manner and the Indian student processes the two as knowledges of different kinds.

Explanation for the Indian students' attitude

One could argue that we have come a long way from 1902 and that today it is no longer possible to make a distinction between modern knowledge and indigenous systems since modern, western methods of knowing the world have come to dominate the mainstream educational institutions. It is precisely this cluster of concerns that Sanjay Seth attempts to forward an explanation for, in his book *Subject Lessons* (Seth 2007). Posing the question of how western knowledge acquired the current status of being the only mode of knowledge from being one of the many modes of knowing, Seth in his book examines the consumption and reception of this modern, Western knowledge in the Indian context. Locating his analysis along the lines of a Foucauldian project of "the history of

knowledge (which) constitutes a privileged point of view for the genealogy of the subject" (4), Seth points out that new knowledges do not just enter the heads of people to permeate it with new ideas but also serve to produce a new subject. Arguing that modern knowledge creates a knowing subject who is set apart from the objects to be known, he points out that the subject, in this once-novel conception of knowledge, was not already present but had to be created through new pedagogic practices and disciplines created by industrialization, capitalism, modern armies and the modern novel. While the process was complex enough even in the West, he argues that it was more so in the Indian context where the instruments for creating the new subjects were "not slowly working away through the centuries of industrialization and the emergence of new disciplinary mechanism of family, prison, school and factory, but were heavily dependent on the violent and coercive agency of colonial rule" (5). Thus, western modern knowledge in India served to create a particular subject but failed to do so fully in the Indian context.

The burden of my argument ...is that while India was transformed and Western knowledge was an important agent in this transformation, this transformation did not principally occur because education 'modernized' those Indians who were subject to it. Even as they engaged with modern institutions, engaged in modern practices, and acquired Western knowledge, Indians often seemed to do so in ways that did not render them modern and that did not accord with the core presumptions of this knowledge (12-3).

In delineating his conception of subjectivity, Seth borrows from Heidegger's "The Age of the World Picture." In the essay Heidegger reflects on the 'essence' of modern science in order to apprehend the metaphysical foundation of the modern age and observes that crucial to apprehending this foundation is the emergence of 'Man' as the new subject in which Man becomes a relational centre of the world. It is possible for 'man' to become the relational centre of that which is, Heidegger marks, only when the comprehension of the whole changes. This change manifests itself in the world emerging as an object that is now available for study and man emerging as a subject, and grasping the world as a picture - as a system. Heidegger notes that the world picture does not change from an 'old' one into a 'new', 'modern' one, but rather the fact that the world is conceived as a picture, becomes a picture at all, is what distinguishes the modern age.

Drawing from Heidegger's insight, Seth poses the question - what if modern knowledge failed to produce a subject and 'the world as picture' failed to emerge in India. Seth indeed suggests that it did not and at points even suggests that this was because 'another' subjectivity, corresponding to 'indigenous' modes of relating to knowledge, was diverting and frustrating the impact of modern education. Seth interprets the long standing complaint against Indian students that they regard western education more from a utilitarian point of view, often learning by rote, thereby defeating the very purpose of modern education which is premised on the idea that knowledge, for it to be so, must be 'truly understood,' as reflecting the anxiety of the failure of modern western education to produce the subject it posited in the first place. He thus reads the discourses and debates in education in India which, he points out, came to be haunted by a spectre of nominalism, as "perturbations on the surface of this knowledge, half-acknowledgements that the foundational assumptions underpinning and enabling modern knowledge could not in fact be assumed" (195). This failure, he warns, is not to be read as another argument of lack, or incompleteness of modernity but as exposing the limits of modern, western knowledge and the presuppositions it makes. In other words, he claims, his is an attempt to problematize the very knowledge by which we judge absence and incompleteness. Thus, according to Seth, to the extent that modern knowledge did not remake Indians, it proved to be 'inadequate' in knowing India.

At a glance, the statement bears a close resemblance to the 'narrative of lack' which has by now been rehearsed several times in our context and which Seth clearly wants to distance himself

from. In the arguments that do make such a claim, the modern subject is marked as the rational, secular, scientific self who is capable of intellectual and moral autonomy and Europe is envisaged as the site and image of modernity where such a subject is produced. Consequently, the history of the non-west typically gets read as lack or incompleteness since it is measured against this normative notion of modernity and then a claim is made for a version of “our modernity”. However, to ascribe the rise of the modern subject to Europe, the subject who is the embodiment of scientific rationality, individualism and secularism is to take the self-descriptions of modernity as self-evident, universal truths. In other words, first we misread what goes under the name of European modernity and against this misreading, measure the modernity of the non-west and produce a narrative of lack or a version of our modernity.

Thus, we could ask - was such a subject produced in Europe? Seth does well to anticipate this question and draws from Taylor and Latour, to suggest that perhaps, the West is not modern either and that “while modern thought has played an important role in constituting modernity, it is not thereby a privileged medium for comprehending it” (194). Thus, Seth steers clear of the lament narrative by making the ‘lack’ a product of modern knowledge which cannot ‘adequately’ know India rather than the property of the non-west or its people. This raises an important question - What is the nature of these normative goals posed by Western knowledge and education such that they are difficult to be acquired, with the ultimate goal always evading us? Any attempt to answer the question requires us to revisit the emergence of the idea of the modern university which was tied intrinsically to the creation of the liberal knowledge and learning.

Secondly, an explanation that holds that because certain sociological conditions that existed in the West did not chronologically exist in the same way in India and therefore the subject did not emerge in India is reminiscent of older theories of “failed modernity”. Though Seth is eager to distance himself from such narratives, underlying his explanation is a similar assumption – an assumption of symmetrical development, which is to expect that all of the functionally inter-related processes within modernity should emerge simultaneously (Kaviraj 2005, 497–526). Though Seth realizes the insufficiency of this explanation and turns his gaze onto the West, it remains a half-hearted exercise. Indeed, by offering a sociological explanation, Seth confuses the subject to be a sociological, empirical entity, an object that emerged in the Western society as a result of a certain sequence of sociological-historical conditions than see it as a theoretical entity that comes into being in the matrix of intellectual ideas. What is the conceptual field in which “the subject” emerges? What is the nature of the “modern subject” such that “to be a modern subject” constantly eludes Indians? - These are questions Seth fails to answer.

Thirdly, according to Seth, Indians acquired Western knowledge without becoming modern subjects. If in Seth’s account, the interdependence of modern knowledge and the modern subject is an essential condition for acquiring modern knowledge, Seth leaves unexplained how indeed it was possible for Indians to sever this essential link.

However, Seth is acutely aware of the limitations of his own frame. Thus, though he reads the growing concern with the problems of “cram” and “instrumentalism” as signifying the failure of modern knowledge to produce the corresponding form of knowing subject and argues that this could indicate the presence of another subjectivity which is frustrating the emergence of the modern subject, he points out that his analysis is both made possible and obscured by the concept of “subjectivity.” He is aware that because he is posing the question within already available categories, the conclusion can only be presented as a “different sort of subject’ which can only be represented as an inadequate or unrealized version of the first. As Seth puts it, the “different” subject can only be a partially realized form of the normative subject, such that all forms of subjectivity ultimately culminate in modern forms

of selfhood, “thereby bringing it under a category which erases with one hand the difference which it writes with the other.” The challenge, as he points out, is to “search for forms of thought which allow us to recognize that there have been and are ways of thinking the world other than modern, occidental ones; but also ways of thinking difference without invoking the Subject.” (Seth 2007, 45)

In-so-far as we try to account for how modern knowledge is received in non-western contexts from within the frame of liberal education, employing the categories it makes available, we are unlikely to come up with anything more than a “lack” narrative, however rich and nuanced the analysis might be. How then do we make the various observations about the Indian student made by the likes of Dr. Stein intelligible, without attributing “ill-intention” or bad motives to the authors of these statements? To simply dismiss Dr. Stein’s anthropological observations as another instance of the negative evaluation of the Orient characteristic of Orientalist descriptions or as serving the interests of the imperial power does not explain as much as “explain away” the issue at hand. Instead, it is fruitful to ask why the Europeans saw what they did, such that their own experience of the Indian student is illuminated.¹³ Simultaneously, how do we understand the Indian students’ attitudes and dealings with modern knowledge, such that they are not rendered merely stupid or dull-headed, without slipping into some form of biological determinism? While the answer to these questions lies beyond the scope of this paper I will gesture, in the next section, towards where we are likely to find the answer to the questions posed above.

Section 3

Inescapable Frameworks?

The answer to the questions raised above, I would like to argue, lies in a genealogical diagnosis which requires us to revisit an earlier moment in European intellectual history, a return to what is famously referred to as the Humboldtian moment.¹⁴ We see here that the roots to the conception of education underlying the university run deep, providing the institution with its self-understanding. It is here that a theory of self-formation is woven with a theory of science, leading to a specific conception of education that results in the emergence of the modern university. What is the model of education represented by *Bildung* as self-formation which emerges as central to the idea of the modern university and liberal education? What was the nature of knowledge pursued and the kind of self-formation involved¹⁵? If *Bildung* is “second nature,” involving the creation of the moral subject through initiation into the “space of reasons”, what were the necessary conditions under which it could take place?

The Humboldtian Moment: *Bildung* and the European Model of Education

In the history of the idea of the European university, “the Humboldtian moment,” is often regarded as the most revolutionary moments, giving birth to the idea of the modern university. If, as Sir Isaiah Berlin points out, “the history not only of thought, but of consciousness, opinion, action...morals, politics, aesthetics, is to a large degree a history of dominant models” (Berlin 1999, 2), then we could conclude with a fair degree of certainty that in the history of institutions of higher education and learning, the Humboldtian model sets the terms of reference. One could of course argue that this emphasis on the Humboldtian moment is rather unwarranted in our context, given that India has a history of British colonialism because of which we inherited the British models of higher learning rather than the German. This observation would indeed be true if one were looking at what differentiates various national systems of higher education within Europe. However, if one wishes to extract the conceptual framework that is common to these different systems of higher education, then it is the famous Humboldtian moment we must turn to – a moment that resulted in giving birth to a

model that went on to become a universal model, though with innumerable variations, with deep resonances throughout Europe and elsewhere, including North America in the late nineteenth century.

Early stages in the self-understanding of the modern university coincide with a rhetoric of crisis in the already existing universities (in hindsight labelled “medieval”). The “modern,” university as inaugurated by the Humboldtian conception acquires its sharpness as a concept because it constitutes itself vis-à-vis three kinds of institutions of higher learning that existed then – the “traditional,” “medieval” university tied to the church where received knowledge was interpreted, the “specialist,” “higher vocational” institutions that had erupted in huge numbers to meet the demands of industrialisation and the lower secondary schools. Thus, “higher” in higher education as embodied in the university, gets its substantive content from defining itself both against the utilitarian ideology embodied by the specialist, technical institutions and the pre-existing universities which operated with a “closed” conception of knowledge¹⁶ as well as the schools which trained pupils to acquire “lower” faculties and capabilities alongside inculcating in them the desire to pursue university education. The Humboldtian moment inaugurated a broader conception of knowledge as necessarily “open” and “unfinished”.

Even though the term pursuing “knowledge for its own sake” has come under much disrepute today, it must be noted that in the Humboldtian conception, the pursuit of objective knowledge *Wissenschaft* (science)¹⁷ was tied to *Bildung*, the development of the person where the idea of education as self-formation was tied to the pursuits of the self (Humboldt 1970). In other words, *Wissenschaft* was the source of *Bildung*, thereby resulting in an internal, integrated merger of pursuit of objective scholarship with subjective transformation. Indeed, the concept of *Bildung* or self-formation, one of the central concepts on which the idea of liberal education rests, was crucial to the Humboldtian moment of revival of the universities, with *Bildung* developing as an extremely influential apolitical¹⁸ educational theory, centring on individual self-formation through the pursuit of knowledge.

The Centrality of the Concept of *Bildung*

The debate around education in the late-eighteenth century Europe, as noted earlier, brings into play the central concept of *Bildung*, a particular ideal of self-formation that captured the cultural imagination of Europe. Scholars have noted that the primacy of the concept did not lag far behind the central concepts of man and humanity (Dumont 1994; Gadamer 2004; Koselleck 2002). Gadamer, who notes the importance of the concept during this period, points out that “the concept of self-formation, education or cultivation (*Bildung*), which became supremely important at the time, was perhaps the greatest idea of the eighteenth century and it is this concept which is the atmosphere breathed by the human sciences of the nineteenth century, even if they are unable to offer any epistemological justification for it” and that philosophy and the human sciences (*Geistwissenschaften* or moral sciences) has “in *Bildung*, the condition for its existence.” (Gadamer 2004, 11) Similarly, Louis Dumont, in his remarkable study of the concept and its influence on Wilhelm Von Humboldt in the “German ideology” draws attention to the almost “institutional” status that the concept came to enjoy in the late eighteenth century European debates:

A conceptual transformation takes place at the end of the eighteenth century in Germany: it is nothing less than the birth of a value-idea, expressed by the word *Bildung*...Let us say, to begin with, that the word designates here education, especially and preeminently self-education...Let us beware, for it (*Bildung*) is a genuine institution...we do not have to reserve the word institution for “political constitutions” or main juridical organizations”. “For what is an institution if not a set of actions and ideas, already in place, that individuals encounter, and that more or less imposes itself on them?” (Dumont 1994, 81–5)

That a concept which emerged in late eighteenth century Europe continues to frame contemporary educational debates is made evident in the frequent evocation of *Bildung* in current discussions on higher education, especially in response to the Bologna process underway in Europe with the aim of turning Europe into a “knowledge society.” (Lovlie, Mortensen, and Nordenbo 2003; Siljander, Kivelä, and Sutinen 2012; Wimmer 2003) However, contemporary discussions focusing on the theory and practice of education have often posed the question along the axis of value of *Bildung* or the lack of it in present times. Thus, in recent times, scholars have either lamented the loss of *Bildung* as a concept, often attempting to reinstate it to provide meaning and direction to our practice of higher education, alternatively have pointed out the impossibility of its use for contemporary times or sometimes even argued for refashioning it in the context of increasing talk about the future of *Bildung* in knowledge society (Readings 1996; Wimmer 2003; Thomson 2001; Biesta 2002). They mostly see *Bildung* either as an ideal to be still aspired to or as a theory of pedagogy or self-formation which has to be refashioned to suit current needs. However, what is this normative ideal of *Bildung* that continues to organize reflections around higher education in the West and why does it continue to organize reflection on education and knowledge in current times?

While most scholars seem to agree that *Bildung* is a key cultural concept in modern educational theory and is crucial to understanding both the idea of the university and liberal education, an attempt to answer a simple question like “what exactly is *Bildung*”¹⁹ seems to be almost an impossible task. Various translated as self-cultivation, culture, education, self-education, self-formation, civilization and higher education, it has recently been made famous by John McDowell as “second nature” that education initiates one into (McDowell 1998, 167–97), even if this association did exist since Hegel’s times.²⁰ For some, the concept of *Bildung* seems to carry echoes of the Arnoldian sense of culture as ‘cultivation’ that has come under severe criticism after the 1980s for its European bias and its links with the values of the middle class elite. However, Koselleck points out that there is enough substantial empirical evidence to prove that *Bildung* was not limited to the bourgeois (*burgertum*) strata, with both the nobility and the non-bourgeois, being bearers of *Bildung*²¹ and that it is important to analytically separate the compound concept of *Bildungsburgertum* which arose only retrospectively in the 1920s. Indeed, a probe into the cultural concept of *Bildung* reveals a much more complicated conceptual history, with the concept carrying a wide range of connotations and a complex semantic structure and history.

The concept *Bildung*, as already pointed out, is widely accepted to be associated with the neo-humanist educational theory of Humboldt who holds a central place among the early proponents of German liberalism²². That Humboldt’s central concept of *Bildung* in the sense of self-formation or self-cultivation which formed the core of Humboldtian political philosophy had resonances beyond Germany and was highly influential in England is made evident by John Stuart Mill’s reference to Humboldt both in his famous essay “On Liberty” and in his Autobiography where he acknowledges that Humboldt’s conception of self-cultivation or *Bildung* was one of the primary influences on his conception of the individual while writing “On Liberty” (Valls 1999). Curiously, the Humboldtian idea of *Bildung* in turn is seen to be inflected by and sometimes coming closest to Shaftesbury’s idea of self-formation and “inward form” which was made accessible through the first German translation of the latter’s *Characteristics* in 1738 and which is regarded as influencing the German idea of *Bildung* in the eighteenth century²³. While these cross-references are indicative of a rapid flow of ideas between England and Germany and the centrality of self-formation and “inward form” in the emergent thought of the time, *Bildung* that crucially shaped the educational debates has a history that can be traced back before the eighteenth century.

***Bildung* and its links to Theology**

The tracking of the journey of the concept indicates that the word has its origins in medieval mysticism and is not conceived in terms of the bourgeoisie or politics but primarily in terms of theology where one's self-perfection was directed towards the image of God. Dumont points out:

From Bild, "picture," and Bilden, "to represent or form," the idea of form has always been essential to the word. Bildung had meant "form" or "formation" in a religious sense since the mystics of the late Middle Ages. The two moments of this "formation" were the opening to the divine grace, followed by its action on the worshipper, whose one and only model, Vorbild, Jesus Christ. We note that pietism strongly stresses subjectivity, although essentially in order to destroy it (Entselbstung). There is a blatant discontinuity between this religious idea of Bildung and the one that is our concern here. (Dumont 1994, 82)

The German word bilden which originally referred to God's creation of human beings in His image is given a more active content by German mystics like Meister Eckhardt and others who believed that the Universal Spirit that emanated from the creator and was present in every being became impure through its contact with bodily matter and thus had to be purified before it could be reintegrated with the creator. The process itself was described "as an "odyssey," during which an individual must "sculpt away impurities" until the soul becomes a "work of art," or virtuous by attaining self-recognition (*gnothi seauton*). Referring to this sculpting metaphor, the mystics called such introspection *bilden*" (Cocalis 1978). Thus, from the doctrine that "God created human beings in his image" followed the possibility of *imitatio Christi* or the *imago dei* where man carries within his soul the image of God after whom he fashions and cultivates himself, with his highest aim being to become an image of God.

However, from being confined to medieval Christian mystic traditions, the concept of *Bildung* becomes dislodged from its theological frame and is "laicized" in the eighteenth century, becoming available to all. Thus, the active process of self-fashioning and moulding that the copy, through constant self-creation, is engaged in, in order to approach the original becomes with secularization of the concept, "rising up to humanity through culture," the basic definition that Herder initially gives *Bildung*. This normative aspect that is built into the idea of modern education as articulated through *Bildung* is best captured later by Heidegger who dismisses the current understandings of *Bildung* as "a cultivation of subjective qualities as a result of nineteenth century misinterpretations" and instead holds that once given back "its original power as a word," it is the word that comes closest to capturing the Greek *paideia*.

The German word *Bildung* ["education," literally "formation"] comes closest to capturing the word(*paidia*), but not entirely. In this case, of course, we need to restore to *Bildung* its original power as a word, and we have to forget the misinterpretation to which it fell victim in the late nineteenth century. *Bildung* ["formation"] means two things. On the one hand formation means forming people in the sense of impressing on them a character that unfolds. But at the same time this "forming" of people "forms" (or impresses a character on) people by antecedently taking measure in terms of some paradigmatic image, which for that reason is called the proto-type [*Vor-bild*]. Thus at one and the same time "formation" means impressing a character on people and guiding people by a paradigm. The contrary of *paidia* is (*apaideusia*), lack of formation, where no fundamental bearing is awakened and unfolded, and where no normative proto-type is put forth. (Heidegger 1998, 166-7)

We see here that *Bildung* is understood actively as a kind of forming that is supposed to direct humans towards pre-given goals which constitute humanity. What is the normative prototype (the pre-given goal) that constitutes the "fundamental bearing" which needs to be unfolded and which Heidegger identifies as essential to the idea of formation? Here, the theological origins of the concept

and the religious ideas and meanings associated with the concept that we have detailed earlier provide us some clue. If one were to go by the concept's theological origin and its use in medieval mysticism, one can conclude that it is fairly clear that the prototype is that of Christ and the idea of self-cultivation/formation involved would be the set of spiritual practices, meditations, abstinence, renunciations and introspection, certain "techniques of the self" (Foucault 2005; Asad 1993) practiced by Christian mystics or monks in medieval monasteries with the aim of purifying the soul in order to attain salvation. These techniques of the self were oriented towards the same goal: The revelation of truth about oneself could not be disassociated from the obligation to renounce oneself, wishing to be no longer the subject of will. As Foucault puts it, in these practices truth about oneself and sacrifice of oneself were closely related: "We have to sacrifice the self in order to discover the truth about ourself, and we have to discover the truth about ourself in order to sacrifice ourself." (1999)

However, with the secularization of the concept, the concept breaks loose from the theological frame and *Bildung* acquires a fresh life, emerging as a rallying point around which the idea of education and self-formation are debated. In this process, a peculiar shift happens in the way formation is now understood. If in Christian mysticism, formation implied sacrifice of self and surrender of one's will, in the subsequent debates around *Bildung*, formation now implies actualizing the self and cultivating of one's will. Drawing upon the Pietistic belief of the sanctity of individual and pre-supposing an elusive notion of soul/self that is in its germination stage and needs to be actualized through the process of education, *Bildung* now represented an ideal of self-cultivation through culture, of "inner worldly living" which would go on to serve as the ideal for the new conception of scholarly research through Humboldt. However, the idea of cultivation continued to retain some of its theological and religious associations which proved decisive in the manner the concept was received and used to promote the culture of the "inward man," fuelling the idea of scholarship as more than just a form of productive labour is effectively brought out by Koselleck:

If Herder, someone who helped the humanistic concept of *Bildung* achieve its breakthrough in its historico-philosophical and cosmological dimension, could still write, "Every man has an image (ein Bild) of himself, of what he shall be and become; as long as he is not yet that, in his bones he is still unsatisfied", then the religious definition of religion clearly and audibly rings through. Even in the young Humboldt, who resolutely liberated himself from every foreign, authoritarian definition of religion in order to advocate spiritual and moral determination, did not escape a Christian-Neoplatonic stereotype: "For all *Bildung* has its origins in the interior of the soul alone, and can be induced by outer events, never produced." The moral man forms himself (bildet sich) "in the image (im Bilde) of divinity through the intuition of the highest idealistic perfection." (Koselleck 2002, 177)

Previously restricted to Christian theology and medieval mysticism, where *Bildung* was the "part of the knowledge of redemption and the sharing in God's grace", now the concept re-emerges as an active device for the eighteenth century Europeans to think through, work out and arrive at the idea of the secular, autonomous individual. How is the concept crafted, reworked and fleshed out and used as a device to express the intellectual and pedagogic articulations of self-formation for newly secularizing times? Understanding this process will tell us why the modern research university as an institution was thought about in a particular light in this period and took the shape it did. In the next section, I explore the relation between *Bildung* and the idea of education that developed with the active usage of the concept during this period. We see here that in the debates that follow *Bildung* is both a pre-supposition even while it is freshly reworked, crafted and given shape to suit newer needs.

***Bildung* and the Idea of Education: A Theory of Self-formation**

Whatever the differences among individual figures, eighteenth century Western thinkers on *Bildung* who drew their educational ideal from the Greek *Paideia*, explicitly formulated education in

terms of the formation of the subject of education. In other words, the concept of *Bildung* always primarily referred to the individual human being who must form himself or herself, irrespective of the circumstances and yet in a dynamic relation to it. Thus it is characterized by a certain kind of reflexivity between one's own actions and the circumstances one finds oneself in, with the relation between the "exterior" and "interior" being central to the personal process of *Bildung*. Thus, education came to be distinguished from "training" which prepared subjects from the point of view of a particular job or from the point of view of "usefulness" external to themselves, or from the notion of "expertise" which was seen as robbing human beings of holistic, harmonious growth of faculties and from the idea of mastering encyclopaedic knowledge or technical reconstruction - all of which were concerned with the external and the immediate and not with the self-formation of the individual and therefore not considered education at all. *Bildung* was necessarily a self-directed activity which necessarily resulted in self-transformation and was a never-ending process. Thus, *Bildung*, Gadamer states, has no goals outside itself (2004, 10).

The goal of education, instead, was the formation of the "whole human being", involving a particular kind of formation, articulated in terms of a concern for individuality, "the cultivation of the individual's humanity." This was often represented as a movement from formlessness to form and immaturity to maturity, involving an unfolding of the form already imprinted in the "formless", the development of a certain "natural" capacity seen as inherent to human nature. Every being is imprinted with an incipient form and the purpose of education is to help the individual realize this pre-given form, conceived as a process of self-actualization. The idea of self-actualization would not just be a fulfilment of a pre-given form or "essence", but also realizing in a determinate way what the form is, the unique form that each one is to realize.

Thus if one dominant idea of education is to regard it as a form of socialization where succeeding generations are inserted into the existing social order or a domain of practices to ensure the full participation in specific forms of life and continuity of a particular social organization, in this tradition of *Bildung*, education was not socialization understood in the usual sense of term (Biesta 2007). For, the "cultivation of individual's humanity" necessarily constituted a movement away from one's tradition to the exercise of one's autonomy and freedom. This movement, as Biesta points out, cannot be seen as going beyond tradition but as a particular form of enculturation or socialization within a particular tradition. This idea of self-formation, captured in terms of the movement from immaturity to maturity of the individual is first fleshed out by Kant in his famous text "What is Enlightenment," (1784), a text that has generated memorable reading by Michel Foucault (2010).

Kant, in his answer to "What is Enlightenment?" defines Enlightenment as "Man's emergence from self-incurred immaturity". Kant defines immaturity in the very beginning as "an inability to use one's own understanding without the guidance of the other," a certain state of our will, which makes us accept others as authority in areas where we need to use our reason. This immaturity is self-incurred if its cause is "not lack of understanding, but lack of resolution and courage to use it without the guidance of another." Thus, Kant argues that human beings should have the courage to use their own understanding. This "Kantian demand for self-determination" expressed in the motto "have the courage to use your own understanding," as Koselleck points out, is a call "directed at the whole person and his self-formation": "The aim was the *Bildung* of the whole human being as his own purpose." (2002, 180)

The condition of tutelage or immaturity, as Foucault in his reading of Kant makes clear, is not a state of "natural powerlessness" or the "natural childhood of a humanity which has not yet acquired the means and possibilities of autonomy," nor "a deprivation of right", nor violence by those who take upon themselves the task of directing you but "simply a result of a certain relationship to ourselves...a

sort of deficit in the relationship of autonomy to oneself", where "cowardice", "laziness" and "fear" keep us, paradoxically, in that condition of tutelage and at the same time prevent us from coming out of it (Foucault 2010, 33). Thus, it is man's own laziness and cowardice are obstacles in the process and not anything external that keeps him in tutelage.

So how does one exit out of this condition and come into freedom? According to Kant, in the condition of immaturity, one only obeys and does not reason. One has exited this condition of immaturity/tutelage and attained majority when one has reinstituted the right connection between obedience and private use of our faculties, on the one hand, and between reasoning and public use of our faculties on the other. In other words, we obey when we are in a professional capacity or involved in a public activity as functionaries where we are parts of a machine with a specific role to play (because in this private use of faculties, obedience is unconditionally good), while we act as universal subjects who can exercise full freedom of reasoning in public use of our faculties, where as rational beings, we make full use of our faculty of reason and address others as rational beings like ourselves. Even today such a use of public reason is the hallmark of the "real" university and a genuinely democratic society.

Kant lays out the regulative end of self-formation which is the attainment of a certain form of "governing the self" – to cultivate the faculty of reason in public use, a capacity, which is already present in each human being but only needs to be developed as a duty to oneself, involving a movement from "passivity" to a morally cultivated human being who can reason, thereby developing the capacity for self-determination or rational autonomy, the normative goal of *Bildung*. In other words, learning to reason is an important means through which one derives one's actions in the world. In this scheme, rational beings are those who ought to have reasons for their actions and ought to act in ways such that they have reason to act in the ways they do. One cannot act in the "dark of reason."²⁴ Thus, here the *formation of character* involved in the "cultivation of mind" requires cultivation of one's will and reason in order to develop the "relation of autonomy to ourselves", thereby emerging as self-determining, moral individuals.

For Kant, the development of inherent capacity to exercise the faculty of reason so that the subject could emerge as autonomous, capable of exercising one's own intentional agency is made possible only through the process of education. Thus, in his later treatise "On Education," (Kant 2003) brought out to the reading public in 1803, Kant would emphasize that "Man is the only being who needs education" and that he can acquire this capacity to reason only through education: "Animals are by their instincts all that they can be ever be; some other reason has provided everything for them at the outset. But man needs reason of his own. Having no instinct he has to work out a plan of conduct for himself. Since, however, he is not able to do it all at once, but comes into the world underdeveloped, others have to do it for him." (11)

However, Kant casts this capacity or potential for autonomous reasoning not as "a contingent, historical possibility" or one particular way of relating to the domain of practices and actions nor as a culturally specific way of enculturing subjects, but as something that is an inherent part of human nature (Biesta 2007, 28). We see that Kant makes freedom understood in the sense of rational autonomy as central, almost essential to the idea of education, a feature peculiar to modern education, a connection unavailable before this period.²⁵ However, what is the nature of this freedom? It must be noted that freedom here is not understood in terms of freedom from earthly existence, or freedom from specific determinations like one's oppressive status in society but specifically in terms of the free exercise of faculty of reason to enable one to self-determine and act without surrendering to any form of external authority, a certain kind of cultivation of will necessary for the formation of a moral subject.

If public reasoning is the faculty that needs to be developed for self-formation, which no State should hinder, what must be the kind of institution that would be ideal for its development and pursuit? Though in his "What is Enlightenment," Kant gives us no clue about how best this faculty could be developed and what kind of an institution would serve the required purpose, he puts forward a model, in his later work. In *The Conflict of faculties* (Kant 1992), which came to be regarded as the blue print of the modern research university and one of the foundational texts of the Humboldtian model, Kant rigorously traces the architecture of the new university through the lens of "conflict" and argues that the faculty of Philosophy would be the one to enjoy this privilege of unrestricted use of reason.

In *The Conflict of faculties*, Kant discusses the conflict between the "lower" faculty of Philosophy²⁶ and "higher" faculties of law, theology and medicine, a contradiction which is constitutive of the university, formed at its very core. While the "higher" faculties of Law, Medicine and Theology, promise utility to the government and train public servants (lawyers, doctors and priests respectively), and therefore are subject to the Government's command and control, Philosophy, "which has public presentation of truth as its function", (55) has to remain independent of the government's command with respect to its teaching.

By its very distance from State power, Philosophy would, in Kant's scheme possess a higher degree of freedom and would be limited by reason alone, free to evaluate everything and concerning itself only with truth, in the interest of *Wissenschaft*. For Kant, Truth is the result of reason's free judgement and is by nature rational and reason by nature free and "admit(ing) of no command to hold something as true" (no imperative "believe" but only a free "I believe," says Kant) (29). Thus, the faculty of Philosophy, embodying the self-legislating exercise of reason in the service of *Wissenschaft* (whose interest/goal is truth), may not be able to command the higher faculties but can control them by evaluating, judging and validating the output of higher faculties, thereby helping them perfect themselves. In other words, it is the duty of the faculty of Philosophy to put to scrutiny the teaching of higher faculty and rigorously examine it both for the benefit of the Government and the higher faculties, both of which are obliged to submit to the faculty of Philosophy in matters concerning truth. It is only through such a constantly self-reflective activity, that Philosophy uses its freedom to critique, which is not to be construed as an attack on the State or higher faculties but as being indispensable for their benefit. In case of a conflict between higher and lower faculty, (given the propensity of higher faculties to rule and give into people's need for short cuts), conflict cannot, and according to Kant, should not, be settled amicably. In other words, such a situation does not call for a settlement but a verdict. This conflict is irresolvable, and can never end, and it is task of Philosophy faculty to keep it going. In case of a situation where the public dismisses Philosophy as inadequate and useless, preferring to seek answers and short-cuts from the businessmen and theologians of higher faculty, Philosophy is powerless and solution can come only from the State. If the State refuses to recognize the value of Philosophy, then it has condemned Philosophy, the very soul or essence of the university to death.

Thus, we see that Kant absolves "higher" faculty of questions of 'truth' since they are directly involved with the State and therefore act in obedience of statutes on which their teaching is based. Instead, as Timothy Bahti observes, Kant makes "truth" purely Philosophy's end and extends this notion of reasoning towards truth to the whole of the university:

"Truth is the first and fundamental condition of the university's knowledges and doctrines. As for "the uses of the university," its essential utility is the judgment of truth. All other utilitarianisms are secondary." (Bahti 1987)

We see here that Kant makes Philosophy as a theoretical activity as essential to the idea of the new research university and central to the acquiring of *Bildung*. *Bildung*, for Kant, clearly could not be acquired through training oneself to be public servants or through the service of utility. *Bildung*, instead, moves in the element of *Wissenschaft*, reason and truth and the process of formation that occurs in the individual through the process of pursuing *Wissenschaft*. Through this move, Kant, institutes a new understanding of what “higher” learning is – not only does higher education now distinguish itself from training oneself in one or the other practical domain, but it subordinates the practical domain itself to the operations of reason. The demand of founding practical knowledge in reason now becomes a universal requirement.

It is interesting to note that in neither of these tracts does Kant directly use the word “*Bildung*,” (he would use it only in his later tract “On education,” by 1800, when it had become virtually impossible to talk about education without employing the concept in overt ways, (Liedman 1993). Yet we see that in his description, there is an active sense of the concept in the way he fleshes out the nature of formation involved.

If in Kant, *Bildung* is still defined in terms of cultivating a capacity or talent that inheres in all human beings, providing the broad contours of the process of self-formation, in Humboldt, the theological content and the association of the concept with the ancient mystic tradition (according to which man carries in his soul the image of God and must cultivate himself in that light) rings through more explicitly:

but when in our language we say *Bildung*, we mean something both higher and more inward, namely the disposition of mind which, from the knowledge and the feeling of the total intellectual and moral endeavor, flows harmoniously into sensibility and character (Gadamer 2004, 31).

Declaring that “all education originates from the inner soul of man, all external arrangements or events can only initiate but not cause education”, thereby distinguishing *Bildung* from any other model of formation which was for external reasons and therefore served as a means to an end, Humboldt did more to canonize and institutionalize the concept of *Bildung* than anybody else. Between 1790 and 1810, Humboldt sought to lay the conditions under which *Bildung* could flourish, unhindered by any external interference even if self-formation could only take place in a dynamic relation to the “external” world of action. How does the concept of *Bildung* undergo transformation through Humboldt, such that it can now create an institutional space for itself, becoming the driving force of pedagogy and defining the purpose of the university?

In his essay *Limits of State Action* (1993), which greatly influenced John Stuart Mill, Humboldt attempts to work out the limits of the State such that *Bildung* of the person could take place without any obstacles. Humboldt was writing at a time when the universities in Germany (like in France and England), were mostly tied to the Church and regarded as notorious for festering unscholarly activities and as a social ill. Since the universities were seen as completely unsuited to the demands of the prevailing times, the Prussian state encouraged several schools, emphasizing practical and technical training for utilitarian purposes.²⁷ It is against these utilitarian institutions on the one hand and the State and Church on the other that Humboldt fleshes out the ideal of *Bildung* and the idea of the university.

Stating that “The true end of Man, or that which is prescribed by the eternal and immutable dictates of reason, and not suggested by vague and transient desires, is the highest and most harmonious development of his powers to a complete and consistent whole,” Humboldt argues that the pre-condition for different faculties to develop in “spontaneous cooperation” is freedom and diversity of situations. How does one achieve this without any hindrance and interference from various institutional bodies? In order to ensure the first condition of freedom necessary for individual

self-cultivation, Humboldt proposes the curtailment of state power to the barest minimum possible, restricted to providing internal and external security. The State must only perform the negative function of providing the outward conditions of freedom because, by interfering too much and by attending to the well-being of its citizen, the State suppresses the energies of its people thereby constricting the personal growth in favour of generating productive and obedient citizens. Thus, Humboldt has a strong critique of the very idea of National education:

National education – or that which is organized and imposed by the State is at least in many respects very questionable. The grand leading principle, towards which every argument hitherto unfolded in these pages directly converges, is the absolute and essential importance of human development in its richest diversity. But national education, since it presupposes the selection and appointment of someone instructor, must always promote a definite form of development, however careful to avoid such an error...Now all systems of National education, in as much as they afford room for the manifestation of a government spirit, tend to impose a definite form of civic development, and therefore to repress the vital energies of a nation. (Humboldt 1993, 65–7)

Humboldt's primary concern here, as Sorkin (1983) points out, is to assert the political sovereignty of man in which the inward development of man, the development of the capabilities of the person, his self-education, is given a priority over man as citizen, for, the person, Humboldt argues, is always more than a citizen. Such a person whose capacities have been allowed to develop to the fullest and capable of self-expression and self-determination would be more than a mere subject of the State, even while being most useful to the State. when required and perhaps, ultimately concern himself/herself with the activity of the State.

Thus, by paring down the State's power, Humboldt delineates a programme that will help meet the first condition for self-formation – the freedom of the individual. The second condition which requires the presence of diversity of situations can be made possible only through social interplay since forming oneself requires developing social bonds. It is in fulfilling this second condition of forming social bonds that Humboldt recognizes the importance of intermediate institutions which stand between the State and citizens, thereby recognizing the institutional setting where true exchange and development of individuals could happen, without interference from State, leading to the formation of the modern university embodied in the University of Berlin.

Humboldt not only lays out the conditions for *Bildung*, but in a fragment written in 1793-94, titled "Theory of *Bildung*," (Humboldt 2000) sketchily works out a theory of *Bildung* that at a rudimentary level tries to conceptualize how the linking of the self to the world through which self-formation occurs, would take place. Emphasizing the relation between the "external" and "internal," between the self and the world, Humboldt notes that man is "naturally" driven to move beyond himself to external objects and that "it is crucial that he should not lose himself in this alienation but rather reflect back into his inner being the clarifying light and comforting warmth of everything he undertakes outside himself." He must, thus, bring objects/matter closer to himself and impress his mind on them, bringing the two into close resemblance.

The impetus to link the self/mind to the world and the constant reworking of the relationship between the internal and external, with movement directed outwards towards the world only to be directed back to oneself such that one's own powers are honed, runs throughout the fragment. Pointing out that within man there are several faculties to represent the same object - as a "concept of reason", "as an image of imagination" and "as an intuition the senses", Humboldt argues that these are different tools to grasp Nature, but the purpose is not to be acquainted with nature from all sides but to hone his own "innate powers" of which these diverse views are "differently shaped effects" brought into unity in the concept of the world: "It is precisely this unity that determines the concept of the

world, a concept that encompasses both the diversity of ways in which the external objects touch our senses and the independent existence through which these objects influence our feelings.” (59)

Humboldt therefore concludes that for self-formation to occur, what man needs most is “*simply an object that makes possible the interplay between his receptivity and his self-activity*”. However, if this object is to occupy his full being, the ultimate object must be nothing less than the world itself:

Man seeks unity only to escape from dissipating and confusing diversity. In order not to become lost in infinity, empty and unfruitful, he creates a single circle, visible at a glance from any point. In order to attach the image of the ultimate goal to every step forward he takes, he seeks to transform scattered knowledge and action into a closed system, mere scholarship into scholarly *Bildung*, merely restless endeavor into judicious activity. (60)

Kant lays out the contours of the process of self-formation and its end, necessary to which is a theoretical orientation to the domain of actions and practices. Humboldt lays down the rudimentary theory of *Bildung*, emphasizing the importance of the objectual world in self-formation and draws the limits of the state by laying down the external constraints such that *Bildung* of the individual could take place unhindered. However, it is Hegel who astutely works out what *Bildung* is in terms of the experience of the individual consciousness, represented as the historical development of the Spirit in various stages. If, as Gadamer says, “what constitutes the essence of *Bildung* is not alienation as such but a return to oneself – which presupposes alienation to be sure,” then it is in Hegel this it is most explicitly brought to surface, though the theme runs through in Kant and Humboldt too.

One of the central problems to which Hegel and other German Idealists were responding to is the problem of alienation. The nature of alienation is what is often seen as the ultimate problem in Western philosophical tradition: the “subject-object duality” (or the disconnection between knowledge and truth).²⁸ In other words, for consciousness, its object (world) is other than itself. This gulf/split between the subject and object is a precondition of the possibility of human knowledge and the “arrival” of knowledge is the erasure of this gulf.

Hegel, in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1977), conceptualizes the education of individual consciousness to science as an erasure of this duality. This stage is reached through the dissolution of internal contradiction which takes the form of ‘negative determination’ and is resolved at a higher level of comprehension, resulting in a new shape which appears one step closer to the truth²⁹. Thus the dualities which begin as oppositions, the consciousness realizes are linked at their very base and are mutually constitutive. However, the dualities are erased but not by going back into some innocent unity of subject and object but through the negative dialectics between consciousness and self-consciousness which unites the oppositions at a higher level of comprehension. This process of *Bildung*, or negative dialectic, which involves a particular form of reflexivity, for Hegel, leads to genuine science. Hegel shows how at the core of ‘formation’ lies the concept of self-consciousness, a necessary condition for *Bildung* to take place.

Conclusion: Observations, Findings and Further Questions

What does my elaborate rendering of the model of education as represented by *Bildung* attempt to do? When we say liberal education and the university of culture does not take root in postcolonial contexts such as ours, what we seem to be saying is that there is a thick notion of education which is not taking root. That this thick notion of education finds it difficult to take root in non-western contexts like ours does not imply that there is something wrong with our social fabric. What it does indicate is that when we try to understand the reasons for the articulation of crisis in our centres of higher learning, we need to go beyond locating it in terms of social and institutional failure

in our context and instead turn to the intellectual and cultural milieu that gave rise to a certain conception of education that informs the institution of the university, giving the institution its specific character. What is this thick notion of education and the idea of formation which seems to be absent in contexts such as ours? Thus, I turned to the Humboldtian moment and the debate around *Bildung* in order to obtain a better grasp of the generative moment which also sets the limits on what is generated. It is against this horizon that we must make sense of our crisis in higher education.

1. The idea of the modern university of culture emerged out of the conceptual matrix of *Bildung*. I tried to historically reconstruct the conception of education that emerged as a result. One of the tasks attempted here is to capture the debates internal to the tradition of *Bildung* – how was education problematized, why was the institution of the university thought about in a particular light and what was the conception of education that emerged from it. The other task I have attempted is to ask a question external to the tradition. I posed the question: What is *Bildung* a response to? Here, I tried to show that *Bildung* is a conceptual tool through which the idea of self-formation is envisaged for newly secularizing times and draw attention to the depth of these debates.

2. In the secular definition of education that emerges with the Humboldtian idea, we see that the assumption that human beings have a pre-given form which they have to realize is a pre-theoretical supposition, thereby providing a normative dimension to the notion of education. Thus, “secular” education comes to presuppose an elusive notion of an incipient self that is germinative and needs to be actualized through education. However, one also witnesses a radical shift in the way formation is now conceptualized. A positive conception of self which involves cultivating one’s will to emerge as self-determining in freedom replaces the earlier idea of formation as the sacrifice of the self which requires a surrender of one’s will to the will of God. What thus emerges is a view of the “secular,” autonomous self, individual defined in abstraction from any order or matrix of practices and actions. While this shift may have been captured by Foucault and Taylor, its implications for modern education remain unexplored. I would like to argue that what indeed happens here is a genealogical shift in the very conception of education: Before this historical point, education is sacrifice of the self. In the debates around *Bildung*, education is the actualization of the self in freedom of self-determination.

3. Freedom in this tradition is conceived as freedom of self-determination of the individual, promoting a dynamic sense of agency, where actions are derived from reasons which further have their basis in principles. Freedom emerges here as a species essence. Thus even feminist and Marxist critiques of liberal education, can be seen as drawing sustenance from *Bildung* where the idea of a self-unfolding subject or fulfillment in freedom of self-determination continues to be an ideal to be realized. Why does the idea of freedom as self-determination become so central to modern education? What kind of relation does it generate between the knowing subject and the domain of actions? And why is the University the best place to foster this link? – are questions to be probed.

4. *Bildung* is often seen as a theory of pedagogy or self-formation, culture as self-cultivation. However, I have tried to relocate it back to its context and see it more as a cultural phenomenon, specific to Europe which then gets characterised as a universal theory of education. It appears that *Bildung* is a concept around which the Western tradition organizes its reflection around knowledge, subject and truth. If as Foucault points out, the Cartesian moment results in a break where the fundamental “link between access to truth, which becomes the autonomous development of knowledge (*connaissance*), and the requirement of the subject’s transformation of himself and his being” is broken with the Cartesian moment, thereby reconfiguring the relation between truth and subjectivity, then we could say that in the history of Western thinking on education, the debate around *Bildung* is an attempt to rethink and suture this break. However, the attempt remains difficult, forcing Foucault to reflect on the impossibility of constituting an ethic of the self in modern times.

5. The return to the Humboldtian moment might help us answer the questions regarding the conceptual and foundational underpinnings of the modern university. It might also give us a glimpse into the limits of the structures of Western thought itself and help us understand why the Europeans provided certain kind of descriptions of the Indian student. That Dr. Stein should condemn the Indian student as a curious specimen for his mental museum because he sees in him the failure of modern education to create a "mature", "self-determining individual" who can provide reasons for his beliefs, practices and actions seems to be an obvious conclusion when viewed from his framework. What Dr. Stein and the debates around the crisis in the Indian university get at is the absence of the thick conception of education and the remarkably different nature of educated selves. The third section then gives us a glimpse of what it is that does not travel even when the institution of university and its attendant structures do get transplanted.

How then do we understand the Indian student's experience of and dealings with modern education? How do we hypothetically characterize the system of education in which the learning strategies of Indian students is rendered intelligible rather than as merely outmoded and backward? What kind of knowledge is this system of education an initiation into, why is the role of the teacher and the exercise of memory so central to the scheme and how do these ways of learning impact our ability to deal with the protocols of modern knowledge?- These are the questions which this paper throws up.

Notes

¹ This paper is part of my ongoing doctoral research titled "Locations of Knowledge: The University, Liberal Education and the Case of India" currently being pursued at the Centre for the Study of Culture at Society (CSCS), Bangalore. A version of the paper was presented at the conference on "Global Conclave of Young Scholars of Indian Education," held at National University of Educational Planning and Administration (NUEPA), New Delhi, January 27-29, 2011.

² The scholarship on the university and higher education in India works with the categories of the "Western" model of the university and the "non-western" one, where Western universities are cast as models worthy of being emulated. By the "West", the scholarship largely refers to European, English and American. I retain this use.

³ The history of the idea and institution of the university is a rich body of study in the West. Rothblatt (1997) points out that the question is not whether the university requires an idea or not but that historically, it has been assigned one and "for two centuries a particular kind of debate has gone on, revived in every generation, concerning the role and purpose of a university and the education it provides" (1). The list of works that engage with the idea of the university and liberal education is too long to mention here but among the more recent works, one can immediately recall Nussbaum 1997; Derrida 2004; Pelikan 1992; Bloom 1987; Readings 1996; Kweik 2006; Lovlie, Mortensen, and Nordenbo 2003; Hancock 1999. Newman's *The Idea of the University*, Martin Heidegger's "Rectorial Address," Jasper's *The Idea of the University* continue to inspire though I have not referred to them here. I have dealt specifically with the German idea of the university which was articulated with much passion towards the end of the eighteenth century, in the last section.

⁴ See Robert Pippin's eloquent and incisive speech on "Liberation and Liberal Arts: The Aims of Education", given to an incoming class in 2000 at the University of Chicago (Pippin 2000). Liberal education, unlike the utilitarian theory of education, conceives of goals as intrinsic to itself and to the development of the idea of personhood. Marxist and feminists accounts of liberal education, despite their critique, presuppose the theoretical concept of the free individual whose potential for self-

activity and self-fashioning is of supreme importance, with capitalism and patriarchy robbing the individual of such potential. Hence, Robert Pippin's point that these critiques only seem to be arguing for pursuing liberal education even more "purely," by drawing attention to the various obstacles that come in the way of the actualization of freedom is very perceptive.

⁵ The narrative of crisis in the University in the West often maps the decline vis-à-vis the Humboldtian university. As noted by many scholars, each nation produced its own institutional arrangements for pursuing the Humboldtian conception of advanced learning (Readings 1996). Rothblatt and Wittrock (1993, 1–15) point out that the problem of defining the university has long preoccupied politicians, planners, reformers, academics, theologians, philosophers, historians and litterateurs and they have often found the task difficult. So much has this been the case, especially since the eighteenth century that universities are now subsumed under a broader if less romantic category of "higher education". And yet the idea of the university and liberal education, *Bildung*, they argue have existed and continue to exist, drawing attention to a particular moral order of which the university is a part, "comprising the cultural or emotional barrier separating the "university" from "higher education."

⁶ Readings observes that the university ceases to be the producer and preserver of national culture, with the central idea of 'culture' being replaced by 'excellence,' an empty vacuous word with no referent. Thus, with a lack of any serious role, Reading observes, the University of Culture (as he calls the modern, Humboldtian university) has given way to the University of Excellence, tilted towards a market-oriented model, with the older ideals of a unifying national culture, *Bildung*, the liberal subject-citizen and the nation-state no longer relevant and asks how best to reside in the ruins of reason and culture, post the critique of Enlightenment values and modernity (Readings 1996). However, the problem in postcolonial contexts such as ours is not that the University of Culture is giving way to the University of Excellence as Readings frames it, but that the University of Culture and the corresponding idea of liberal education never takes root, except in some minimal, nominal form.

⁷ See for example, the prolific literature around the crisis in the university in the Indian context. A quick glance at various media articles, reports, reviews and scholarly writings on the subject reveals a rather depressing and gloomy picture of our university system – it is always in "decline", "disarray", "decay" "crisis", "shambles", "mortgaged" or a "system in atrophy" and is acutely in need of "reform", "rejuvenation" and "transformation". The former HRD Minister Arjun Singh, in *the Times of India* described higher education in India as a "sick child," ("Higher Education Is a Sick Child", 2007) The National Knowledge Commission note on higher education refers to the "quiet crisis" in the universities that is not discernible because there are pockets of excellence, and scholars point out that the success of a few professional and technical institutions is masking the crisis that runs deep in our universities (*The National Knowledge Commission Note on Education* 2006). That we don't have "real" universities, our universities have failed to be centres of knowledge production, our students prefer going abroad for higher education in huge numbers, our universities neither produce employable students nor train students to pursue higher studies in basic sciences, our students take up higher education largely for utilitarian reasons and do not understand the protocols of knowledge – are only some of the anxieties around the institution of the university in India. See Kapur and Mehta 2004; Kapur 2008; Agarwal 2006; Vaidyanathan 2008. Refer to Deshpande 2008; Chatterjee 2002, for a different, more cautious response to the perception of crisis, especially in social science research. For a more recent debate on the quality of college education in India, see Thane Richard's article (Thane 2013) and the interesting responses to it in Kafila.org.

⁸ Indeed, when the National Knowledge Commission recommends 1500 universities by 2015 in India, it is not clear what exactly they are reproducing, especially when under their own admission our

existing universities, are in “deep crisis.” This contradiction is highlighted by Jandhyala B. G. Tilak (2007) who points out that though the average enrolment size of universities in India is around 6000, there are several existing universities which have a very small level of enrolment, much below requirement.

⁹ Liberal Education hardly evokes any passion in non-western contexts. However, when used, it remains vague, without any substantial content.

¹⁰ See in particular Seth 2007, 18–45, where he examines the growing concern with cramming and instrumentalism in late nineteenth and early twentieth century. Interestingly, more or less similar complaints can be heard against the undergraduate student today. However, the explanation forwarded today is that the students are from disadvantaged castes and therefore are not motivated enough, are less bright and pursue higher education only in order to gain employment. The fact that these concerns were expressed in the beginning of the twentieth century when it was likely that the Indian students referred to were largely upper caste makes it clear that caste is immaterial to the issue.

¹¹ The Beginning of modern higher education is traced back to the establishment of Hindu College in 1817 in Calcutta by Raja Rammohan Roy. By 1853, the number of colleges had risen to 25. Post the recommendation of Wood Education Dispatch in 1854, three universities in the Presidency towns of Bombay, Calcutta and Madras were set up in 1857. The main function of these universities was to conduct examinations and award degrees, while teaching work was to be done in the affiliated colleges. This was an adoption of the London University model. With the rapid rise in enrolment, Punjab University at Lahore (1882) and the University of Allahabad (1887) were also established. After this, no new university was set up in the Nineteenth Century. By 1902, there were five universities and 191 affiliated colleges with a total enrolment of 17,650 students. See (Kuppusamy 2009, 51–8).

¹² This is a paradigmatic case. I have chosen this because it best represents in one conversation the kind of concerns that dominated the debate around university education, knowledge and learning at that time.

¹³ Said (1978) notes that Orientalism should be seen as imposing a limit on European thinking about the “Orient”. Thus rather than reduce Orientalism to a body of knowledge that crudely serves some imperial interests, one should ask what makes Europeans perceive the Orient the way they do and what are the elements structuring the cultural experience of the West such that its self-description and other-description have certain features (Dhareshwar 2005, 194–206).

¹⁴ Modern academia and scholarship trace the origin of the modern university to the idea of the Humboldtian University in the early nineteenth century. Many scholars emphasize the importance of the Humboldtian idea all over the continent in the nineteenth century, with the idea eventually crossing the Atlantic to have a tremendous influence on the Anglo-American world as well. The idea of the university is seen to have caused a fundamental transformation in the very structure of academic knowledge, resulting in the creation of modern “disciplines” as the new social and intellectual forms through which knowledge would be classified and produced. See Howard (2006); Readings (1996); Kweik (2006) among several others who emphasize this point. In the Indian context, we have combined the liberal arts college idea from British universities like Oxford and Cambridge, with the idea of the Humboldtian research university, pioneered in Germany in the early nineteenth century, as it is in most postcolonial nations, including the United States.

¹⁵ *Bildung* emerged as a central concept around which education, knowledge and the university was debated, with the leading thinkers of the times – Kant, Humboldt, Schelling, Hegel, Fichte among others - participating in the debate. Eventually this intellectual milieu gave birth to *the idea* of the modern university.

¹⁶ R. W. Southern (Southern 1995,11) points out that the theory of knowledge on which the scholastic system was based – that is to say, the idea that knowledge was a reconquest of that which had been freely available to mankind in a pre-lapsarian state – encouraged the expectation of a slowly enlarging body of authoritative doctrine growing from century to century, and needing in this stage of the world only to be harvested and organized. If this was a true account of the function of the schools, it would be equally applicable to natural sciences as to the science of theology, law, logic and grammar. They all exemplified the slow recovery of that intuitive knowledge of all things with which the human race had been endowed with at creation, and which - despite the ravages of sin – it was slowly recovering and combining in a single system the knowledge lost by Adam and Eve. It is this “closed” conception that is contrasted with the idea of knowledge as “open” and “unfinished” and in the future.

¹⁷ *Wissenschaft*, though normally translated as science, referred to the systematic pursuit of any body of knowledge organized on definite principles, including history and philology. Thus, it included not just the natural sciences like physics but also what we would call human sciences today.

¹⁸ When I say *Bildung* developed as an apolitical theory, I mean that it provided a theory of education which was education of the self, not subordinate to either the state (education for citizenship) or market (education for the industry). Thus, the question was how to create conditions such that *Bildung* could take place, without the state or market being obstacles in the process. Hence, the centrality of Humboldt’s *Limits of State Action* [1792].

¹⁹ My account of *Bildung* largely draws from Humboldt’s *Limits of State Action*, (1993); Kant’s *What is Enlightenment* (1784) and Hegel’s *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1977), besides several secondary sources on *Bildung*, mainly Koselleck’s “On the Anthropological and Semantic Structure of *Bildung*” in Koselleck 2002; Kweik 2006; Sorkin 1983; Dumont 1994; Gadamer 2004.

²⁰ McDowell sees *Bildung* as a central process through which innate potentialities in human beings is transformed into second nature, into habits of thought and action. It is through this one acquires conceptual capacities, thereby becoming responsible to “space of reasons.”

²¹ “Free self-formation for all” was the slogan of the times! (Koselleck 2002, 181)

²² Raymond Geuss (2001, 71) points out that Humboldt’s *The Limits of State Action* is one of the most influential (yet most neglected) texts on the history of liberalism. This is despite the fact, he admits, that there was no liberalism as a political movement and no concept of liberalism when Humboldt wrote his work. However, he points out that this anachronism is useful to capture the early moments of liberalism. One could argue that though antecedents of liberal education predate liberalism, what is common to both of them is the theoretical presupposition that the essence of human nature is freedom.

²³ Indeed, some of Humboldt’s ideas are pre-figured in Adam Smith whose idea of education as public good does not derive from the argument that education should be for national prosperity, economic self-interest or for increasing economic productivity, as is commonly thought today. He instead makes an argument for why education is the “only effective remedy” for the ills of a modern commercial society and is essential for introducing one to a “variety of situations” and to help hone one’s intellectual activities, to counter the “mutilation” and “deformation” caused due to uniform, repetitive

tasks introduced by industrial revolution. See Rothschild (1998). One can find a similar argument in Gramsci (2001) who argues against the rise of the vocational institutions on somewhat similar grounds.

²⁴ Hence, Robert Pippin, in his inaugural lecture on “Aims of Education” to the incoming class of 2000 at University of Chicago, remarks that if one does not the reason for one’s action, they are not one’s own: “Unless you have some idea of why it is better for you to be here (at the university of Chicago) rather than anywhere else or at any other university or whatever, then you did not *come here freely*. There is an element of alienation or strangeness *to you* in your presence here. Some crucial part of your life, while it was in fact produced *by you*, does not truly reflect the “you” that you understand yourself to be and identify with, and so this decision cannot in the deepest sense *be yours*” (Pippin 2000).

²⁵ Perhaps implicit in Beista’s observation that Kant makes freedom central to the idea of modern education, is that the connection between education and freedom is not available before Kant.

²⁶ Kant makes it clear that the nomenclature “higher” and “lower” is adopted with reference to the Government rather than the learned professions. Philosophy (the lower faculty) is further divided into *historical sciences* comprising history, geography, linguistics, humanities and *pure rational sciences* comprising pure mathematics, pure Philosophy, metaphysics of nature and of morals. Currently we could take Philosophy to mean Human and Natural Sciences, all of which are under Philosophy at the time Kant is writing. (Kant 1992, 45). Here, Philosophy refers to a certain theoretical orientation that characterizes the Sciences

²⁷ By the last decade of the century, intellectual endeavors had shifted to scientific academies and there was call from various sides demanding the abolition of universities. The numbers of universities were seen as too many in number, and an unnecessary burden on state finances, especially since with secularization, the financial support to these universities which originally came from the church had reduced. Public support to these universities had weakened to such an extent that during the Napoleonic era, twenty two universities disappeared, in what has been termed as a ‘mass death’ of universities (Ziolkowski 1990, 218–308).

²⁸ The concept of alienation itself needs to be unpacked. Here alienation could mean two things – a) self-alienation where human beings are alienated from God. b) alienation between mind and World / subject and object. Does alienation happen when consciousness develops self-consciousness, a certain form of reflexivity? Thus, Pippin (1989) points out, modern philosophy is animated by the activity of reflection, a turning around the mind to examine itself. This form of reflexivity is integral to the process of *Bildung*.

²⁹ Hegel works with the assumption that the world is rational and hence is intelligible to us. Thus any intelligibility or tension is not part of the world but is generated by our conceptual lenses/tensions.

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